Indian *duab*, but it had really been the Kushanas of the early centuries CE who had last *re*-conjoined the Iranian and Indic cultural worlds for the millennium to come. Despite a short imperial life of only about seven decades, the Shansabanis – specifically the Ghazna lineage – can be credited ultimately with leaving a substantial footprint in northern India. We are prepared, then, for examination of the separate and yet intertwined historical processes unleashed by the Ghazna Shansabanis in northern India, and their westward reverberations (Volume II).

Serving as a pivot between Volume I and Volume II is the question aptly phrased by T. Barfield: "at what point should we stop treating [the Shansabanis] as an example … of pastoral nomads and begin thinking of them as elites with a nomadic pastoral heritage and history?"[1] This query is particularly germane, as the Shansabanis' entire imperial activity took place within a little more than half a century, and was thus within the lifetimes of clansmen who, based on the localized circumstances of their bases of power, effected transitions from *more* nomadic/transhumant to *more* sedentist lifeways (cf. Chapters 3 and 4).

The fundamental question posed by Barfield may have multiple answers as well as a singular, overarching one. The region-specific responses of the three Shansabani lineages – shifting lifeways and economies as circumstances required – demonstrated the complex flexibility of the nomad–urban continuum. It could also be said that non-elite empire-builders became "elites with a nomadic pastoral heritage and history" when it behooved them to think of *themselves* as such, desiring their court historians to project courtly images of them. And yet, the textual episteme of the Persianate world afforded little conceptualization of *non*-courtly kingship, historical reality being frequently sublimated *via* Persian historiographical conventions (cf. Chapter 1). Ultimately, the ineluctable historical trace is the Ghazna Shansabanis' expansion into the Indus valleys and the north Indian *duab*: for them, like their millennial predecessors the Kushanas (cf. Introduction), nomadism and/or transhumance appeared to be inextricable from their particular mode of empire-building, as it was their specifically derived "cultural capital"[2] (discussed in Chapters 1 and 5) that made such a vast, transregional and transcultural imperialism possible. It could be the case that the Shansabanis *never* fully transformed from nomadic or transhumant pastoralists to "elites with a nomadic pastoral heritage and history."

Notes

1. Barfield 2003.
2. Cf. Irons 2003.